

LittleReads

Zara and the Missing Moonbeam

Adventure

Ages 5–7

by LittleReads Editorial Team

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Every evening, when the sky turned the colour of ripe mangoes, a single beam of moonlight would land right in the middle of the magical garden of Nkemdilim. The flowers would open their petals wider, the fireflies would dance, and everything felt safe and warm.

Chapter 1: The Missing Light

Zara noticed it first. She was sitting on the old stone bench with her grandmother, watching the sky, when the garden grew dimmer than usual.

"Mama Nkechi," Zara whispered. "Where is the moonbeam?"

Her grandmother looked up. The moon was there, round and bright, but its light seemed to miss the garden entirely.

"Hmm," said Mama Nkechi, stroking her chin. "That has never happened before. Perhaps the moonbeam has lost its way."

Zara looked at the garden — the flowers drooping slightly, the fireflies confused, the little pond reflecting only darkness. Something had to be done.

"I will find it," said Zara, standing up with determination.

Mama Nkechi smiled. "Then you will need courage, patience, and a good pair of walking shoes."

Chapter 2: The Path of Stars

Zara packed a small bag with water, a biscuit, and a little torch — just in case. She kissed her grandmother goodbye and stepped onto the path that wound through the Whispering Woods.

The path was lit by stars overhead, but it was darker than Zara expected. Branches reached out like gentle fingers, and owls hooted softly in the distance.

"Do not be afraid," Zara told herself. "The moonbeam needs me."

After walking for a while, she came to a fork in the road. One path went left, toward the river. The other went right, toward the mountains.

Then she noticed something. On the left path, she could see the faintest silver glimmer on the leaves. It was very small, but it was there.

"That way," she said, and followed the silver traces.

Chapter 3: The Wise Tortoise

The silver traces led Zara to the banks of the Whispering River. There, sitting on a rock as still as a statue, was an old tortoise.

"Good evening, child," said the tortoise. "You look like someone on a quest."

"I am looking for the moonbeam," said Zara. "Have you seen it?"

The tortoise blinked slowly. "I did see a strange silver light cross the river about an hour ago. It went toward the Meadow of Echoes."

"What is the Meadow of Echoes?" Zara asked.

"It is a place where things go when they are confused. Things that have lost their purpose sometimes wander there, waiting to be found."

"Then that is where I must go," said Zara.

The tortoise nodded. "You are brave for your age. But remember — the answer you seek may not be what you expect."

Chapter 4: The Meadow of Echoes

The Meadow of Echoes was beautiful but strange. The grass was soft and blue-grey, and the air was filled with gentle whispers — echoes of laughter, echoes of songs, echoes of things half-remembered.

In the middle of the meadow, Zara saw a small light flickering. It was not as bright as the moonbeam should be. It seemed tired.

Zara walked toward it slowly. "Hello? Are you the moonbeam?"

The light wobbled. Then, in a voice like wind chimes, it said, "I am. But I am not lost. I am tired."

"Tired?" asked Zara, sitting down on the grass.

"Every night, I travel from the moon to your garden. I have done this for hundreds of years. But tonight, I felt so heavy. I could not make the journey."

Zara thought about this. "Why do you travel to our garden every night?"

"Because the garden needs me. And because your grandmother sits there every evening, and the moonbeam makes her smile. I do it for the smiles."

Chapter 5: The Journey Home

Zara sat with the moonbeam for a while. She told it about Mama Nkechi, about the flowers in the garden, about the fireflies that danced every night.

As she spoke, the moonbeam began to glow brighter. Each word of gratitude, each story of joy, seemed to fill it with energy.

"I think," said the moonbeam, "that I just needed to remember why I make the journey."

She held out her hands, and the moonbeam floated gently into her palms. It was warm, like holding sunshine.

Together, they walked back through the meadow, across the river, and through the Whispering Woods. Zara talked the whole way — about flowers, about her grandmother, about the simple joys of home.

By the time they reached the garden, the moonbeam was shining brighter than ever.

Chapter 6: Home Again

The moonbeam landed in the centre of the garden, and suddenly everything came alive. The flowers opened wider, the fireflies danced, and the little pond sparkled with silver light.

Mama Nkechi looked up from her bench and smiled.

"You found it," she said.

"It was tired, Mama. It just needed to remember why it comes."

Her grandmother pulled her close. "That is a lesson for all of us, Zara. Sometimes we forget our reasons. And sometimes, all we need is someone to remind us."

Zara sat on the bench beside her grandmother, watching the moonbeam dance across the garden. The fireflies joined in, and the flowers hummed softly.

And every evening after that, Zara would sit in the garden and whisper a small thank you to the moonbeam — just in case it ever forgot again.

What We Learned

- Zara showed courage by going on a quest alone at night.
- She used problem-solving skills to follow the silver traces.
- The tortoise taught her that answers are sometimes different from what we expect.
- The moonbeam was healed by kindness and gratitude.

Discussion Questions

1. Have you ever been brave even when you were a little scared?
2. Why is remembering why we do things important?
3. How can you show gratitude to people who help you?

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Thank you for reading!

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